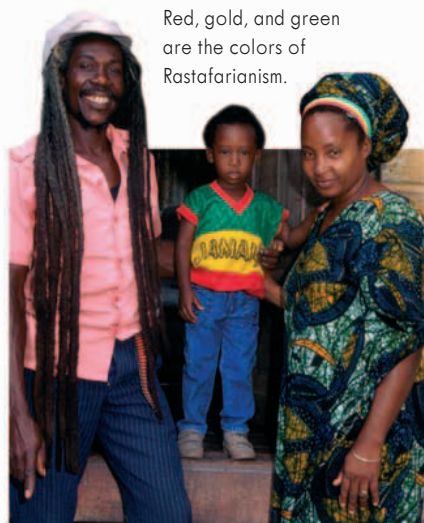




The People of Central America & the Caribbean

THE NARROW LAND MASS and the sprinkling of islands that lie

between North and South America are home to a wide variety of peoples. In general, they are *Mestizo* or *Ladino*—a mix of indigenous American and immigrant ancestry.



Red, gold, and green are the colors of Rastafarianism.

RASTAFARIANS

The ancestors of today's Afro-Caribbeans were taken to the islands from Africa as slaves. The Rastafarian religion, founded in Jamaica in 1930, involves the beliefs that Emperor Haile Selassie of Ethiopia is the Messiah, and that his followers will one day return to their homeland. The word Rastafarian comes from "Ras Tafari," Haile Selassie's given name.

PANAMA CANAL

Opened on August 15, 1914, the Panama Canal took nearly 8,000 miles (13,000 km) off the journey from New York to San Francisco, and brought money and jobs to Central America. Its construction, paid for by the US and France, took 34 years and involved the loss of over 30,000 lives.



THE WAY TO SAN JOSÉ

Most large cities in Central America were founded centuries ago by the first colonists; their modern face blends this historic past with hallmarks of the modern world such as glass-walled buildings, and massive public sculptures. Shown here is downtown San José, the capital city of Costa Rica.

